ECON 101: PRINCIPLES OF MICROECONOMICS
Spring 2025

Time and venue: MWF, Siena Hall 313
Instructor: Dr. Aakanksha Melkani; amelkani@siena.edu; (518)-783-2929
Office: Kiernan Hall 102D
Office hours: MW 11.30am – 12.30pm; T 10am – 1pm

Course Description
This course is an introduction to economic theory at the micro level, i.e., at the level of an individual, firm, farm, organization, etc. The goal will be to familiarize students with key economic concepts including demand, supply, and the formation of equilibrium prices in product and resource markets. The most important prerequisites are an interest in the subject, a willingness to commit the necessary resources in terms of time and intellectual effort, and a desire to actively participate in the learning process. Students should be prepared to deal extensively with the *graphs*, basic *algebraic concepts*, and *detailed technical language*.

Learning goals
The core learning objectives for the course are listed below.

1 Demonstrate understanding of the fundamental microeconomic concepts.
2. Critically analyze and interpret economic data.
3. Apply economic reasoning to analysis of current events and case readings.

Course Materials
The basic readings for the course will be from open-source reading material which can be downloaded free of cost. We will also rely extensively on the on-line instructional system **Canvas**. Homework, notes, and links to readings will all be posted there.
Two textbooks we will be following are listed below. **You are encouraged to download their e-book versions on your laptop/tablet/smartphone.**

- **Principles of Microeconomics 3rd Edition by OpenStax** (https://openstax.org/details/books/principles-microeconomics-3e/?Book%20details)
- **The Economy 2.0 by the CORE** (https://core-econ.org/the-economy/index.html). You need to register in the CORE-ECON website to download this book.

Communication
Apart from the classroom instruction, I will extensively use your Siena email id and Canvas to communicate with you. **PLEASE check your email and Canvas regularly for new communication and announcements.** You are encouraged to communicate and seek guidance with the instructor, especially during the office hours. You can also communicate through email and setup appointments if the office hours do not work for you. I will try to reply to all emails within 24-hours during working hours (Monday to Friday, 8AM to 5PM). My responses during other times may be slow so please plan your work ahead and do not keep urgent questions for the weekend.

Assessment and Grading
The course grade will be determined by taking the weighted average of your performance in the following activities:

Type	Description	Grade	Weight
Instructor Assessment	**In-class assignments:** Short assignments to be solved and submitted in class either individually or within groups. **If you miss a class, you miss the grade** from that day's assignment.	300 (30pts*10)	30%
	Exams: Two, pen-and-paper, in-class exams worth 150 points each. Each exam will cover material covered up to the day before the exam. The potential exam dates are mentioned under the class schedule. Absence from the exam will lead to a zero grade unless you have an exceptional reason and/or you have taken prior permission from the instructor.	300 (150pts*2)	30%
	Group project: You will work on a group project in the later part of the semester and will present your work to the class in the final week of classes.	100	10%
	Final test: A final test will be held on the last day of class.	50	5%
Peer Assessment	**Group project**: There will be a peer evaluation component to the group project. Details will be shared later.	100	10%
Self Assessment	**Surprise quizzes** distributed across the semester based on material covered in recent classes. A few re-attempts will be allowed. Please stay vigilant for updates during classes.	100 (10pts*10)	10%
	Short essays: You will write and a few short essays on current economic issues. You will be allowed one re-attempt. Details will be shared later.	50 (25pts * 2)	5%

Grades: Final grades will be determined based on the following break-up.

		B+	85 to < 90	C+	72 to < 75	D+	62 to < 68	F	<50
A	>= 94	B	80 to < 85	C	70 to < 72	D	58 to < 62		
A-	90 to < 94	B-	75 to < 80	C-	68 to < 70	D-	50 to < 58		

Class Schedule (Class schedule is subject to change and any updates will be announced via Canvas)

Week	Dates	Topic
Week 1	3-Sep	Introduction
	5-Sep	Key economic concepts: Marginal analysis, Opportunity cost, Utility, Scarcity
Module 1: Production Theory – How do firms allocate their resources?		
Week 2	8-Sep	Firm, costs, revenue, profit, production, factors of production, production function, short and long run in economics
	10-Sep	
	12-Sep	Marginal product, Law of Diminishing Marginal Product
Week 3	15-Sep	Cost and cost curves (short run only); Total, average and marginal cost; Costs in long run and Economies of scale (briefly);
	17-Sep	
	19-Sep	Profit maximization
Module 2: Consumer Theory – How do consumers allocate their resources?		
Week 4	22-Sep	Key concepts: Utility, scarcity, preference, choice
	24-Sep	Example of choice between work and spending time on leisure
	26-Sep	Individual utility maximization*:* Consumption bundles and Utility (as a subjective measure of fulfillment)
Week 5	29-Sep	Budget constraints, Indifference curve, Marginal rate of substitution.
	1-Oct	
	3-Oct	
Week 6	6-Oct	Consumer Equilibrium: Intersection of budget constraint and indifference curve
	8-Oct	
	10-Oct	Consumer choices – Income and Substitution effects
Week 7	13-Oct	Exam Review
	15-Oct	**Exam 1**
	17-Oct	**Fall Break**
Module 3: Demand, Supply, Prices and Markets		
Week 8	20-Oct	Fall Break
	22-Oct	Asynchronous activity - no class
	24-Oct	Intro to Demand and Supply Schedule
Week 9	27-Oct	Demand, quantity demanded, demand schedule and demand curve, law of demand; Supply, quantity supplied, supply schedule and supply curve, law of supply
	29-Oct	
	31-Oct	Price Determination, market clearing and equilibrium
Week 10	3-Nov	Elasticity
	5-Nov	
	7-Nov	
	10-Nov	Consumer and producer surplus, welfare analysis

Week 11	12-Nov 14-Nov	Taxation Submission of group members
Week 12	17-Nov 19-Nov 21-Nov	Different types of markets – perfect competition, monopolies, price discrimination, monopolistic competition. Welfare analysis of different types of markets
Week 13	24-Nov	Submission of group presentation synopsis Thanksgiving break
Module 4: Institutions		
Week 14	Dec1 **Dec 3**	Exam review **Exam 2** Introduction to concepts of institutions, power, efficiency, fairness, equity, endowments
	Dec 5	Group presentations in class
Week 15	8-Dec	**Last day of classes - Final test**

Attendance and leave policy
Attendance is primarily through in-class participation in class assignments. If you miss a class, you miss the grade for that day's assignment – THERE IS NO EXCEPTION TO THIS RULE. Since each in-class assignment is less than 1% of your grade – **Please stay home of you are unwell**. If you need a longer leave (more than 3 classes in a row) due to medical or other personal reasons – Please contact me as soon as possible.
For more details on university policies please see: https://www.siena.edu/offices/health-services/medical-leave/

Make-up exams
Make-up exams are given only for excused absences or if the student has obtained the instructor's prior approval. If you miss an exam with an unexcused absence, you will receive a zero for the exam. If you miss an exam for an unforeseen reason, you should contact me as soon as possible. If there has been an extraordinary reason for excessive absences, such as prolonged illness, a student may petition the Vice President for Academic Affairs in writing to consider reinstatement in the class or permission to withdraw with the grade W. It is the personal responsibility of the student to make up all work assigned during an absence from any class or lab.

School of Business Mission Statement
We offer a business education integrated with the liberal arts and rooted in the Franciscan values of inclusivity and service. Our AACSB-accredited undergraduate and graduate programs develop versatile and socially responsible citizens with the skills to compassionately lead, serve, and succeed.

School of Business Learning Outcomes

The School of Business provides intellectually challenging educational programs in Accounting, Economics, Finance, Management, and Marketing that empower our students to address the challenges of an ever-changing world and a diverse society. Each School of Business graduate will attain the following outcomes:

1. Decision Making - Students will make and implement sound decisions.
2. Communication - Students will demonstrate effective communication skills across platforms and audiences.
3. Teamwork and Leadership - Students will demonstrate effective leadership and team member skills.
4. Social Responsibility - Students will recommend actions that consider the impact on all stakeholders, the external environment, and the natural world.
5. Personal Development - Students will have the foundation to build personal and career success.
6. Business Specialization - Students will address organizational challenges and opportunities by applying the in-depth perspective of business specialization

Economics Department Mission
The mission of the Economics Department at Siena College is to educate undergraduate students in a learning environment that emphasizes both mainstream and heterodox approaches to economics, as well as principles of economic justice related to Siena's Franciscan tradition. The Economics Department offers a curriculum that is taught critically and comparatively to promote inquiry and intellectual growth for students, department faculty, and the campus community. The B.A. offers students the opportunity to focus on the relationship between economics and society, while the B.S. requires training in functional areas of business.

Economics Department Learning Goals
-*Concept mastery*: Show mastery in central concepts of mainstream and heterodox approaches to economics.
- *Inquiry:* Provide critical and comparative inquiry through engagement with texts, models, and data. (Includes critical thinking, problem solving, and data analysis.)
- *Policy analysis:* Analyze policy with respect to mainstream and heterodox approaches to economics, and principles of economic justice related to Siena's Franciscan tradition.
- *Communication:* Demonstrate intellectual growth by communicating inquiry-based findings